Dec. 7, 1952

[illegible] (180

WHAT I LEARNED FROM THE RUSSIANS

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[illegible] Krichevski, a Military Government [illegible] whom I knew to be responsible for the care of Soviet Army men who deserted from their eastern [illegible]. Assuming an air of knowing a great deal more than I did, I asked him, "What's all this about a 'Russian' poisoning a [illegible] of [illegible]?"

"[illegible]," said [illegible], "we don't write about it yet—not till we've done more detective work."

"Agreed," I [illegible]. And here is the story of the poisoning case, told now [illegible] in American intelligence circles.

The Soviet target was a group of Red Army deserters who were living with Krichevski in a three-story German house in the American-occupied sector of the city, pending their departure for Western Germany. The [illegible] fugitives from the communists included two women. The most important deserters were a handsome twenty-eight-year-old Soviet engineer and a Russian army technician—civilian—who not only knew [illegible] aerial and transportation centers throughout Eastern Germany but [illegible]. Obviously, the Soviet authorities would want to stop the flow of information from these deserters to us.

"And they darn near succeeded, [illegible]," Krichevski observed. "They had [illegible] planted in the house, so they [illegible] picked a time when I was away and the coast was clear. If it hadn't been for Rita (Krichevski's pretty wife) the Soviet plan might have worked."

Strange as it seems, no American guard was permanently attached to the house. This state of affairs naturally simplified things for the poisoners.

According to the facts brought out in the official investigation, the poison had been mixed in with the cereal served for Monday-morning breakfast. The bitter taste of the cereal caused the Soviet engineer and the civilian to become suspicious. They sent the cereal back. But the rest of the group ate at least part of their portions. The biggest helping was eaten by a robust, black-haired sergeant from the Caucasus. The distribution of the poison had been crudely done and the unfortunate sergeant with the keen appetite managed to eat a heavily dosed portion. As a result, he remains paralyzed today from the waist down.

The sergeant, naturally enough, was the first to get sick. Within an hour, he was retching miserably. This caused the Soviet engineer and the civilian technician to become even more firmly convinced that Soviet terrorists were engaged in a poisoning operation. Rita, who had seen enough to learn quite a little about Russian tactics, agreed to call the American military police.

Unfortunately, the military policeman who turned up was a nice young [illegible] Western boy new to the weird world of Berlin. He assured Rita that she was just "imagining things," and that the sickness was "probably just a case of ptomaine poisoning." But he consented to take the victims over to the [illegible] for a checkup and to bring them back in the evening.

At the hospital, the Soviet deserters were given routine stomach-pump treatment for food poisoning, then returned to the house. The military police did yield to Rita's fears to the extent of ordering special patrols to circle the house during the night. But all was quiet. The next morning the military police were firm in their conviction that Rita had been imagining things. To these young amateurs at the game of international intrigue it felt justified in pulling off the patrols.

But meanwhile Rita had reached her husband in Munich with her report of the poisoning. Krichevski flew home immediately. Sleepless and anxious, Krichevski returned late Tuesday afternoon, some thirty hours after the poison had been eaten by the deserters.

According to our Intelligence authorities, there had been several unconfirmed reports of a strange poison used by the Soviet secret police and by communists in Eastern Europe. "We had been told," Krichevski said, "that the Soviets sometimes used a narcotic which deprived the victims of any will of their own, and which at the same time enabled them to perform physical feats beyond the capabilities of a normal person."

Rita first took her husband to see one of the Soviet women who had been having a particularly bad time. When they entered, the woman was abed.

Krichevski described the scene this way: "She answered questions sensibly enough in normal conversation, but her reactions were slow. Her eyes were still glazed. I decided to try an experiment. In a loud, commanding tone of voice, I told her to get out of bed, stand up and then touch her forehead to her toes. Now, as you know, that's an extraordinarily difficult feat for any adult. Nevertheless she got out of bed and, in a slow, trancelike way, bent over and touched her forehead to the floor."

When Krichevski found that other poison victims responded to orders in the same trancelike manner, he concluded that it must be the same type of narcotic reportedly used by the Russians. And, more important, it was also clear that anyone under the effect of such a narcotic would unconditionally follow the orders of any would-be kidnapers who could gain access to the [illegible] of them.

But because of the skepticism of the American military police, Krichevski decided to take what precautions he could on his own. First, he assembled all the Soviet deserters and put them in the second-story dining room, in the dead center of the house. Krichevski himself placed his mattress—and his gun—near the window of the bedroom normally occupied by the Soviet civilian technician and the sergeant. Then he sat down to wait for what he was pretty sure would come.

As Krichevski tells it: "I hadn't had any sleep for a couple of days and I guess I dropped off. I was awakened by the barking of my female boxer. I could see a man on the drainpipe exactly at my floor level and just one window away. I fired and kept on firing. He slid down the drainpipe and stumbled across the field to the road. One of those big old-fashioned German cars was waiting for him. There were two men in it."

Krichevski had the satisfaction of finally convincing the skeptics. Berlin had just had one of its comparatively heavy snows. The raider's footprints were clearly outlined. A trail of blood showed that he had been hit.

The final chapter in the fantastic episode was to identify the agent who actually had done the poisoning. It was an obvious suspect, a pretty White Russian girl named Katrina, who had functioned as an assistant housekeeper. She had been recommended by a White Russian priest in one of Berlin's refugee camps. She had also won the confidence of others among Krichevski's colleagues.

Rita had become suspicious of Katrina the morning of the poisoning, because of the frantic haste with which she disposed of the plateful of cereal which the Soviet engineer and the civilian had sent back to the kitchen. Yet, with the American authorities convinced at the time that the whole affair was nothing but ptomaine poisoning, there was little Rita could do. When on Tuesday morning, Katrina asked to be allowed to return to the refugee camp and pick up some things, Katrina naturally never showed up again at either place.

Three things convinced the American authorities that Katrina was almost certainly a Soviet agent. The most important was that our own informers later positively identified Katrina as working at Karlshorst, the Soviet headquarters in Berlin's suburbs. Secondly, a search of her room turned up two candles, one long and one short, with which she could have signaled the would-be kidnapers on Monday, warning them to stay away because of the military-police patrols. Finally, when she departed, ostensibly for the refugee camp, she left behind the most of her worldly possessions and never attempted to call for them.

After Krichevski's encounter with the raider on the drainpipe, the pendulum of official interest in the poisoning incident swung violently. High-level officials demanded action, and a thorough investigation followed.

The day after the shooting, the Soviet poison victims were rushed back to the hospital to see if any trace of the poison could be recovered. It was far too late. A small sampling, however, was taken from the stomach of one of the two boxers belonging to the Krichevskis. The male dog died after eating the cereal. Oddly enough, even this sampling "disappeared" between Berlin and American Intelligence headquarters at Heidelberg, where it was being sent for analysis.

The moral of this tale is, whenever the Russians are concerned don't dismiss anything just because it seems too fantastic to be true.

The Berlin poisoning case is merely one of many such unpleasant incidents which filled my memorandum file in 1948 and 1949. It had not always been so. For, in the early days of the occupation of Germany, many Russians, as well as Americans, seemed taken in by the glowing communiqués that emanated from the international conferences. In fact, my first encounter with a citizen of the proletarian dictatorship was a very lucky one for me. I recorded the details in a memorandum dated August 7, 1945. Here is the memo, incidentally the first entry in my file on the Russians:

"Been hearing a lot of jokes about crude Russian equipment and the primitiveness of their methods. But when the mechanical age lets you down, those primitive means can be lifesavers—as I found out last night.

"Drew Middleton, correspondent of The New York Times, and I were returning to cover an assignment when our tire went flat on the *Autobahn* at a point in the Soviet Zone, about twenty miles west of Berlin. (The city of Berlin sits about 110 miles behind Russia's front [illegible] in Germany.) This trip to Berlin was my first into Soviet-held territory. It was getting dark. And because of the [illegible] known, the atmosphere was [illegible] creepy. I didn't feel any more comfortable when our [illegible] crumpled and bent [illegible] while Middleton and I were in the midst of our tire-changing [illegible].

"The few American cars and [illegible] that whizzed by refused to [illegible] our distress signals. Perhaps one reason was that my car was a [illegible] make—a little German sports [illegible] had once belonged to Nazi Foreign Minister Joachim von Ribbentrop.

"After about a half an hour of [illegible] less signaling, I waived a [illegible] feet to an Autobahn turnout, [illegible] managed to stop a [illegible]. In it were two Soviet [illegible] cers and a plump woman surrounded by baggage. This wasn't an ideal rescue crew, but I was too desperate by then to pass up any chance of help.

"'Auto kaput. Have you a jack?' I said in halting German, attempting at the same time to describe the tool [illegible] gestures.

"The Soviet officer in the driver's seat—a major—now got out of the car. After watching with obvious bewilderment my [illegible] pantomime, he countered in French, with, 'Perhaps, by chance, madame speaks French?'

"What a relief! Madame did speak French. So it seemed that the problem was solved.

"But, as it turned out, the Soviet officer had no jack either. He had a solution, though. He stopped a [illegible] of three big Russian trucks and ordered the crews—some seven dirty [illegible] rough-looking enlisted men—to follow us. Our curious caravan proceeded on foot down the road to my car. Here the Russian major asked the [illegible] Middleton to [illegible] the tire-changing tools. Then the Russian officer told the soldiers to pick up the front of the car and hold it. They strained under the weight of that car for at least two minutes and then the tire was changed. Hooray for primitive methods!"

The Berlin I visited in August, 1945, was wide open—at least for a few weeks. We Americans were taking over our sector of Berlin. It was apparent that many Soviet soldiers still thought the entire city theirs to exploit. American newsmen, for their part, wandered pretty freely through the Soviet sector. I remember going with Russell Hill, then chief of the New York Herald Tribune Berlin bureau, to a Soviet officers' club. We invaded it with [illegible], returning to our own press camp [illegible] with tins of caviar, gifts from our surprised but generous hosts, as well as with $400 worth of Reichsmarks which Hill obtained through the sale of his twenty-dollar watch to a Soviet captain. I also remember that only two days later Martha Gellhorn, the noted author, and Charles Collingwood, of CBS, were arrested and held seven hours at a Soviet *Kommandantura* for attempting to visit the same club.

Soon after my arrival in Berlin, I heard reports that the Russian occupation officials had been ordered to avoid all social contacts with Westerners when such meetings were not approved in advance. About the same time a Russian acquaintance, who used to purchase caviar for me in the Soviet "[illegible]," of just exchange, sent a frantic note asking me not to [illegible] see him any more, because if I did, he might be sent back to Russia on charges of fraternization with the West.

Despite these depressing developments, I returned from the Nuremberg